UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Literary Criticism

District • 2020



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • District • 2020

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The group of nineteenth-century French poets who wrote impersonal poetry in reaction to the prevailing romanticism of the first half of the century and who were influenced by the "art for art's sake" doctrine is the

   A) Imagists.
   B) Inkhornists.
   C) Parnassians.
   D) Phosphorists.
   E) Physiocrats.

2. The phrase coined by John Ruskin that denotes any false emotionalism resulting in a too impassioned description of nature is

   A) affective fallacy.
   B) intentional fallacy.
   C) logical positivism.
   D) pathetic fallacy.
   E) transferred epithet.

3. The Canadian writer and "master of the contemporary short story" who received the 2013 Nobel Prize for Literature is

   A) Nadine Gordimer.
   B) Doris Lessing.
   C) Alice Munro.
   D) Nelly Sachs.
   E) Sigrid Undset.

4. The often ludicrous effect, intended or otherwise, resulting from the unsuccessful effort to achieve dignity or sublimity of style is known as

   A) bathos.
   B) ethos.
   C) logos.
   D) mythos.
   E) pathos.

5. **Not** a form of poetry considered to be a pattern poem is the

   A) altar poem.
   B) *carmen figuratum*.
   C) figure poem.
   D) rebus.
   E) shaped verse.

6. The process by which an unhealthy emotional state produced by an imbalance of feelings is corrected and emotional health is restored, especially in terms of an audience's response to the fate of a tragic hero, is known as

   A) catharsis.
   B) dramatic irony.
   C) hubris.
   D) mixed figures.
   E) peripety.

7. The nine goddesses represented as presiding over the various departments of art and science are known as the

   A) Furies.
   B) Graces.
   C) Humors.
   D) Muses.
   E) Nine Worthies.

8. The prolific novelist, essayist, screenwriter, and recipient of the 1986 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for *Lonesome Dove* is

   A) Cormac McCarthy.
   B) Larry McMurtry.
   C) Philip Roth.
   D) Peter Taylor.
   E) John Updike.

9. The early twentieth-century American author of *The House of Mirth*, *The Marne*, *The Age of Innocence*, and *Ethan Frome* is

   A) Willa Cather.
   B) Harper Lee.
   C) Ursula K. Le Guin.
   D) Alice Walker.
   E) Edith Wharton.

10. Writing that reads the same from left to right and from right to left is called a(n)

    A) acrostic.
    B) boustrophedon.
    C) palindrome.
    D) reversal.
    E) telestich.

11. The financial support that until well into the nineteenth century provided authors and other artists who could not make a living on their writing or art alone the wherewithal to continue to create is called

A) acknowledgements.
B) collaboration.
C) decadence.
D) inscription.
E) patronage.

12. The genre of science fiction in a mode popular after 1975 characterized by elements from artificial intelligence, robotics, and advanced computing on one hand and the mid-seventies derivatives of garage rock on the other, a genre that includes the novels of William Gibson's trilogy, is known as

A) apocalyptics.
B) cyberpunk.
C) fantasy.
D) magical realism.
E) utopian.

13. The period in English literary history that reflects the rise of nineteenth-century British imperialism and a growth in British cosmopolitanism, as well as the emergence of the scientific revolution that distinguished nineteenth-century thought, is the

A) Modernist Period.
B) Neoclassical Period.
C) Post-Modernist Period.
D) Realistic Period.
E) Romantic Period.

14. Strictly speaking, any drama whose setting is in a period earlier than that in which it is written is a(n)

A) avante-garde play.
B) history play.
C) miracle play.
D) noh play.
E) well-made play.

15. The early twentieth-century British author of *Heart of Darkness*, *Youth*, *Lord Jim*, and *Nostromo*, is

A) Kingsley Amis.
B) Joseph Conrad.
C) Ford Madox Ford.
D) Rudyard Kipling.
E) W. Somerset Maugham.

16. The belief, including especially the concept of fate in classical literature (and later in Calvinistic teachings and Marxist writing), that all ostensible acts of the will are actually the result of causes that direct them is known as

A) archaism.
B) determinism.
C) expressionism.
D) meliorism.
E) sentimentalism.

17. The period between the Jacksonian Era and the close of the Civil War that saw the testing of a nation and its development by ordeal and which was characterized by westward expansion, the increasing gravity of the slavery question, and the impulse toward reform in the North is the

A) Naturalistic and Symbolistic Period.
B) Period of Conformity and Criticism.
C) Postmodernist Period.
D) Realistic Period.
E) Romantic Period.

18. Pure or serious comedy that appeals to the intellect and arouses thoughtful laughter by exhibiting the inconsistencies and incongruities of human nature and by displaying the follies of social manners is known as

A) boulevard drama.
B) *commedia dell'arte*.
C) high comedy.
D) low comedy.
E) satire.

19. The diagram that is often used to reflect the structure of a five-act tragedy is known as (a/n)

A) episodic structure.
B) Freytag's pyramid.
C) hermeneutic circle.
D) lipogram.
E) quintain.

20. **Not** one of nineteenth-century American author Mark Twain's many novels is

A) *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn.*
B) *The Adventures of Tom Sawyer.*
C) *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court.*
D) *Roughing It.*
E) *The Scarlet Letter*.

21. The period characterized by a gradual tempering of romantic impulse and the steady growth of realism in English letters, noted for the authors Tennyson, Browning, Arnold, and Swinburne, among others, is known as the

A) Early Victorian Age.
B) Modernist Period.
C) Neoclassic Period.
D) Post-Modernist Period.
E) Romantic Period.

22. An inappropriateness of speech resulting from the use of one word for another that resembles it is known as a(n)

A) Erastianism.
B) Euphemism.
C) Grundyism.
D) Malapropism.
E) Spoonerism.

23. The 1971 Pulitzer Prize for Drama was awarded to the author of the novel *The Pigman* for his compelling play *The Effect of Gamma Rays on Man-in-the-Moon Marigolds*,

A) Edward Albee.
B) Charles Fuller.
C) David Mamet.
D) Neil Simon.
E) Paul Zindel.

24. A term applied to any book printed during the last part of the fifteenth century that resembles the conventional medieval manuscript in size, form, and appearance is

A) chrestomathy.
B) duodecimo.
C) folio.
D) incunabulum.
E) quarto.

25. The twentieth-century American author of *The Heart Is a Lonely Hunter*, *The Ballad of the Sad Café*, and *The Member of the Wedding*, is

A) Willa Cather.
B) Kate Chopin.
C) Zora Neale Hurston.
D) Ursula K. Le Guin.
E) Carson McCullers.

26. The poet whose *Collected Poems*, a volume that includes "The Frigate Pelican," "In This Age of Hard Trying, Nonchalance Is Good and," and "The Pangolin," garnered her the 1952 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry is

A) Elizabeth Bishop.
B) Rita Dove.
C) Marianne Moore.
D) Sylvia Plath.
E) Anne Sexton.

27. An interlude in which a drama's actors freeze in position and then resume action as before or hold their positions until the curtain falls is (a/n)

A) establishing shot.
B) hiatus.
C) macrosegment.
D) suspense.
E) tableau.

28. The form of extended metaphor in which objects, persons, places, and actions in a narrative are equated with meanings outside the narrative itself is a(n)

A) allegory.
B) allusion.
C) almanac.
D) paradox.
E) parody.

29. The names John Wycliffe, John Purvey, Miles Coverdale, William Tyndale, Thomas Cranmer, John Rogers, and William Whittington are associated with English-language translations of

A) the Bible.
B) Cervantes.
C) Dante.
D) Homer.
E) Virgil.

30. **Not** among the well-known tetralogies of either the British literary canon or the modern American literary canon is

A) Lawrence Durrell's *Alexandria Quartet*.
B) Philip Roth's Zuckerman novels.
C) J. K. Rowling's Harry Potter series.
D) Shakespeare's Richard and Henry plays.
E) John Updike's Rabbit Angstrom novels.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with William Shakespeare's *The Tragedy of Othello, The Moor of Venice.*
Items 37-42 are associated with Kurt Vonnegut, Jr.'s *Player Piano*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Percy Bysshe Shelley's poetry (selected).

31. Early in Shakespeare's *The Tragedy of Othello, The Moor of Venice*, Iago reveals that "but for [his own] sport and profit," he would never waste time with "such a snipe" as

A) Cassio.
B) the Duke of Venice.
C) Lodovico.
D) Othello.
E) Roderigo.

32. The controlling image in Othello's assessment of Desdemona, "If I do prove her haggard, / Though that her jesses were my dear heartstrings, / I'd whistle her off and let her down the wind / To prey at fortune," is

A) archery.
B) falconry.
C) fencing.
D) soothsaying.
E) tatting.

33. The twice-repeated question "Wouldst thou do such a deed for all the world?" witnesses

A) Cassio's contempt for drunken brawling.
B) Desdemona's disdain for infidelity.
C) Emilia's enmity for thievery.
D) Lodovico's loathing of domestic violence.
E) Othello's obloquy for disloyalty.

34. **Desdemona's response** to Othello's "Ay, and for [the loves you bear me] thou diest," **"That death's unnatural that kills for loving,"** points to the

A) ambiguity of the Italian language.
B) hyperbole in Desdemona's imagery.
C) irony in Brabantio's death.
D) oxymoronic nature of spousal feuds.
E) paradox in Othello's reasoning.

35. Iago's "Her honor is an essence that's not seen; / They have it very oft that have it not, / But for the handkerchief—" is an argument for

A) carrying a handkerchief while in Cyprus.
B) concrete evidence.
C) investing in haberdashery.
D) learning to embroider.
E) needlepoint memorabilia.

36. Scornful of the Duke's advice regarding the loss of his daughter and exclaiming "So let the Turk of Cypress us beguile / We lose it not so long as we can smile" is

A) Brabantio.
B) Cassio.
C) Iago.
D) Lodovico.
E) Othello.

37. In Kurt Vonnegut, Jr.'s fantasy *Player Piano*, the "training ground, where fresh graduates [are] sent to get the feel of industry and then [move] on to bigger things" is (the)

A) Gottwald farm.
B) Homestead.
C) Ilium works.
D) Meadows.
E) Pittsburg.

38. Paul discovers that Finnerty has taken the gun out of the glove compartment when

A) Anita finds it at the Gottwald farm.
B) Finnerty shows up with it at the Meadows.
C) Paul discovers it behind the player piano.
D) Paul says that he is going to report it missing.
E) Pond finds it at the Gottwald farm.

39. In the railway station, among the mechanical carnage, Paul watches a man "smiling because his hands [are] busy doing what they [like] to do best":

A) feeding feral kitties.
B) gesticulating while acting in a skit.
C) playing chess with a machine.
D) replacing men like himself with machines.
E) writing repair manuals for player pianos.

40. Paralleling if not underlying the surface of Vonnegut's dystopian world, one in which machines are in the ascendancy, is the very real concern,

A) Can machines write great fantasy novels?
B) How is an energy source for all the machines built?
C) How many robots does it take to change a light bulb?
D) What can replace the human taxpayers?
E) What happens to the people who have been replaced?

41. "With each new inconvenience, the place became more irresistible. It was a completely isolated backwater, cut off from the boiling rapids of history, society, and the economy" describes the

A) bar at which the player piano provides the music.
B) Gottwald farm.
C) Meadows.
D) rabbit hardware store.
E) repair site at which the Reeks and Wrecks work.

42. "I'm sick of being treated like a machine! You go around talking about what engineers and managers do to all the other poor, dumb people. Just look what an engineer and manager did to me!" is

A) Anita's comeback to Proteus.
B) Barbara's reply to Ed.
C) Janice's rejoinder to Kroner.
D) Katherine's retort to Calhoun.
E) Martha's response to Ed.

Items 43-47 refer to Percy Bysshe Shelley's

To Wordsworth

Poet of Nature, thou hast wept to know
That things depart which never may return:
Childhood and youth, friendship and love's first glow,
Have fled like sweet dreams, leaving thee to mourn.
These common woes I feel. One loss is mine
Which thou too feel'st, yet I alone deplore.
Thou wert as a lone star, whose light did shine
On some frail bark in winter's midnight roar:
Thou hast like to a rock-built refuge stood
Above the blind and battling multitude:
In honoured poverty thy voice did weave
Songs consecrate to truth and liberty,—
Deserting these, thou leavest me to grieve,
Thus having been, that thou shouldst cease to be.

43. Percy Bysshe Shelley's paean-turned-elegiac "To Wordsworth" depends on a repeated use of the figure of speech, the

A) analogue.
B) hyperbole.
C) metaphor.
D) simile.
E) volta.

44. The cutting short of a word through the omission of a letter or a syllable inside a word as found in line six of Shelley's "To Wordsworth" constitutes an example of

A) apostrophe.
B) ellipsis.
C) metathesis.
D) pleonasm.
E) syncope.

45. The continuation of the sense and the grammatical construction of a line on to the next verse as found in Shelley's moving from the octave to the sestet is known as (a/n)

A) end-stopped line.
B) enjambment.
C) hiatus.
D) reduplication.
E) run-on line.

46. Percy Bysshe Shelley's "To Wordsworth" is an example of a(n)

A) Anglo-Italian sonnet.
B) caudate sonnet.
C) English sonnet.
D) Miltonic sonnet.
E) Petrarchan sonnet.

47. The tone of the poem shifts in line 13, and in doing so, reveals Shelley's

A) disappointment in Wordsworth.
B) fear of being without a mentor.
C) love for Wordsworth.
D) mourning over Wordsworth's death.
E) veneration of Wordsworth.

Items 48-50 refer to Percy Bysshe Shelley's

To Jane. The Invitation (excerpted)

Best and brightest, come away!
Fairer far than this fair Day,
Which, like thee to those in sorrow,
Comes to bid a sweet good-morrow
To the rough Year just awake
In its cradle on the brake.
The Brightest hour of unborn Spring,
Through the winter wandering,

continued

Shelley continued

Found, it seems, the halcyon Morn
To hoar February born.
Bending from Heaven, in azure mirth,
It kissed the forehead of the Earth,
And smiled upon the silent sea,
And bade the frozen streams be free,
And waked to music all their fountains,
And breathed upon the frozen mountains,
And like a prophetess of May
Strewed flowers upon the barren way,
Making the wintry world appear
Like one on whom thou smilest, dear.

48. In Percy Bysshe Shelley's "To Jane. The Invitation," the repetition of the word *and* at the beginning of successive lines (lines 13-17) constitutes

A) anaphora.
B) epanalepsis.
C) homeoptoton.
D) homeoteleuton.
E) symploce.

49. The repetition of two words in close proximity that have the same root as in the second line of Shelley's apostrophe is an example of

A) merism.
B) pleonasm.
C) polyptoton.
D) polysyndeton.
E) tautology.

50. The describing of one kind of sensation in terms of another type of sensation as found in line 11's "azure mirth"—the metonymically auditory in terms of the visual color—is known as

A) conceit.
B) litotes.
C) synæsthesia.
D) synecdoche.
E) zeugma.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism

Items 51-60 refer to Samuel Taylor Coleridge's

The Nightingale (excerpted)

No cloud, no relique of the sunken day
Distinguishes the West, no long thin slip
Of sullen light, no obscure trembling hues.
Come, we will rest on this old mossy bridge!
You see the glimmer of the stream beneath,
But hear no murmuring: it flows silently.
O'er its soft bed of verdure. All is still.
A balmy night! and though the stars be dim,
Yet let us think upon the vernal showers
That gladden the green earth, and we shall find
A pleasure in the dimness of the stars.
And hark! the Nightingale begins its song,
'Most musical, most melancholy' bird!
A melancholy bird? Oh! idle thought!
In Nature there is nothing melancholy.
But some night-wandering man whose heart was pierced
With the remembrance of a grievous wrong,
Or slow distemper, or neglected love,
(And so, poor wretch! filled all things with himself,
And made all gentle sounds tell back the tale
Of his own sorrow) he, and such as he,
First named these notes a melancholy strain.
And many a poet echoes the conceit;
Poet who hath been building up the rhyme
When he had better far have stretched his limbs
Beside a brook in mossy forest-dell,
By sun or moon-light, to the influxes
Of shapes and sounds and shifting elements
Surrendering his whole spirit, of his song
And of his fame forgetful! so his fame
Should share in Nature's immortality,
A venerable thing! and so his song
Should make all Nature lovelier, and itself
Be loved like Nature! But 'twill not be so;
And youths and maidens most poetical,
Who lose the deepening twilights of the spring
In ball-rooms and hot theatres, they still
Full of meek sympathy must heave their sighs
O'er Philomela's pity-pleading strains.

51. Samuel Taylor Coleridge's conversational poem "The Nightingale" is set

A) at noon.
B) during the wee hours of the morning.
C) in the afternoon.
D) in the late, late evening.
E) in the morning.

52. Coleridge's invitation to "rest on this old mossy bridge" (line 4) begins a sequence of statements, all of which designate the poem as an example of

A) apostrophe.
B) metonymy.
C) rhetorical accent.
D) synæsthesia.
E) synecdoche.

53. The *murmuring* of line 6, "But hear no murmuring," is an instance of

A) assonance.
B) consonance.
C) onomatopoeia.
D) verisimilitude.
E) wrenched accent.

54. The two types of imagery not informing lines 1-32 of "The Nightingale" are

A) auditory and tactile.
B) gustatory and olfactory.
C) tactile and auditory.
D) tactile and olfactory.
E) visual and tactile.

55. The *strain* line 22 and the *strains* of line 39 are

A) bagpipes droning.
B) conceits.
C) overreachings.
D) pulled muscles.
E) tonal expressions.

Items 56-61 refer to John Clare's

The Flight of Birds

The crow goes flopping on from wood to wood,
The wild duck wherries to the distant flood,
The starnels* hurry o'er in merry crowds,
And overhead whew by like hasty clouds;
The wild duck from the meadow-water plies
And dashes up the water as he flies;
The pigeon suthers by on rapid wing,
The lark mounts upward at the call of spring.
In easy flights above the hurricane
With doubled neck high sails the noisy crane.
Whizz goes the pewit** o'er the ploughman's team,
With many a whew and whirl and sudden scream;
And lightly fluttering to the tree just by,
In chattering journeys whirls the noisy pie;***
From bush to bush slow swees the screaming jay,
With one harsh note of pleasure all the day.

* starlings; a kind of bird
** pewit: a kind of bird
*** magpie: a kind of bird

56. The repetition of initial consonant sounds that characterizes several lines of Clare's poem is

A) alliteration.
B) assonance.
C) consonance.
D) dissonance.
E) resonance.

57. The repetition of sibilant sounds in "From bush to bush slow swees the screaming jay" (line 15) is

A) assonance.
B) consonance.
C) heteroglossia.
D) onomatopoeia.
E) sigmatism.

58. The metrical pattern characterizing the poem is

A) anapestic heptameter.
B) dactylic trimeter.
C) iambic pentameter.
D) ionic hexameter.
E) trochaic tetrameter.

59. The imagery that John Clare uses to present the flying of various birds in his poem "The Flight of Birds" is principally

A) auditory.
B) gustatory.
C) olfactory.
D) tactile.
E) visual.

60. John Clare's sixteen-line lyrical tribute to the flight of birds is constructed of

A) alcaics.
B) blank verse.
C) couplets.
D) distiches.
E) envoys.

61. The "one harsh note of pleasure" (line 16) with which Clare's lyric poem ends is

A) æsthetically pleasing.
B) anthropomorphically paradoxical.
C) dissonantly zeugmatic.
D) oxymoronically alliterative.
E) without antecedent.

Items 62-65 refer to Robert B. Shaw

Shut In

Like many of us, born too late,
(like all of us, fenced in by fate),
the late October fly
will fondly live and die

insensible of the allure
of carrion or cow manure,
Within doors day and night
propelled by appetite,

he circles with approving hums
a morning's manna-fall of crumbs
hoping to find a smear
of jelly somewhere near

62.

In such an easeful habitat
while autumn wanes and he waxes fat
and languorous,* but not **satisfied stillness**
enough to let the swat

of hasty, rolled-up magazine
eliminate him from the scene.
Outside, the air is chill.
62. Inside, he's hard to kill

Patrolling with adhesive feet
the ceiling under which we eat,
he captures at a glance
the slightest threat or chance,

and flaunts the facets of his eyes
that makes him the prince of household spies.
62.
And as he watches, we,
if we look up, will see

a life of limits, like our own,
enclosed within a temperate zone,
not harsh, not insecure,
no challenge to endure,

but yet, with every buzz of need,
by trifles running out of speed.
One day he will be gone
Then the real cold comes on.

62. The stanza form of Robert B. Shaw's "Shut In" is the

A) cinquain.
B) dizain.
C) quatorzain.
D) quatrain.
E) triolet.

63. The analogue of line 14's autumn's waning and line 36's "real cold" is (the)

A) "adhesive feet."
B) "late October fly."
C) loneliness.
D) mortality.
E) onset of winter.

64. Line 31's second descriptor, "not insecure," is an example of

A) braggadocio.
B) hyperbole.
C) litotes.
D) solecism.
E) tautology.

65. Line 10's "morning's manna-fall of crumbs" is a

A) biblical allusion.
B) classical allusion.
C) historical allusion.
D) literary allusion.
E) topical allusion.

Required Tie-Breaking Essay Prompt
on the Next Page

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Percy Bysshe Shelley's "An Exhortation," and offer an understanding of Shelley's comparing of the poet's need to be versatile to "an evanescent [short-lived], semi-visible creature," the chameleon.

An Exhortation*

Chameleons feed on light and air:
  Poets' food is love and fame:
If in this wide world of care
  Poets could but find the same
With as little toil as they,
  Would they ever change their hue
  As the light chameleons do,
Suiting it to every ray
Twenty times a day?

Poets are on this cold earth,
  As chameleons might be,
Hidden from their early birth
  In a cave beneath the sea;
Where light is, chameleons change:
  Where love is not, poets do:
  Fame is love disguised: if few
Find either, never think it strange
That poets range. **change**

Yet dare not stain with wealth or power
  A poet's free and heavenly mind:
If bright chameleons should devour
  Any food but beams* and wind,* **see line 1**
They would grow as earthly soon
  As their brother lizards are.
  Children of a sunnier star,
Spirits from beyond the moon,
O, refuse the boon! **stroke of luck**

*** an address or communication emphatically urging someone to do something**

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE THIS KEY TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST.

UIL Literary Criticism
District • 2020

line arrows up ➔

1.	C	352	31.	E	1.3.427
2.	D	356	32.	B	3.3.301
3.	C		33.	B	4.3.72
4.	A	51	34.	E	5.2.49
5.	D	401	35.	B	4.1.20
6.	A	77	36.	A	1.3.241
7.	D	310	37.	C	42
8.	B	603	38.	D	83
9.	E	571	39.	D	338
10.	C	347	40.	E	
11.	E	357	41.	B	150
12.	B	127	42.	A	249
13.	D	400	43.	D	445
14.	B	235	44.	E	469
15.	B	570	45.	B	174
16.	B	137	46.	D	300
17.	E	422	47.	A	
18.	C	233	48.	A	24
19.	B	211	49.	C	372
20.	E	561	50.	C	469
21.	A	161	51.	D	
22.	D	284	52.	A	37
23.	E	608	53.	C	337
24.	D	251	54.	B	
25.	E	580	55.	E	
26.	C	604	56.	A	13
27.	E	472	57.	E	
28.	A	12	58.	C	
29.	A	54	59.	A	
30.	C	549	60.	C	112
			61.	B	349
			62.	D	395
			63.	D	
			64.	C	275
			65.	A	

FOLD along the **three** longitudinal lines for ease in grading. ➔

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties. ***Simply adjust ranking***.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

DO NOT mark (cross out) actual **LETTER** answer; mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

Page numbers refer to the *Handbook* 12e,

the Folger's updated *Othello*,

the Dial Press *Player Piano*,

and

Oxford World's Classics P. B. Shelley collection.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Shelley's "An Exhortation"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

alliteration,
antithesis,
apostrophe,
diction (word choice),
feminine (double) rhyme,
imagery,
metaphor,
meter,
rhyme scheme,
simile,
synecdoche, and
tone.

The young writer should recognize the operative presence of the simile (lines 5, 7, 11, 24) and the metaphor (lines 2, 16, 25, 26).

Shelley's comparing a poet's focus on love and fame to a chameleon feeding on "light and air" (line 1) and on "beams and wind" (line 22) underlies the comparison *in toto*, so a student's attention to this foundational comparison suffices.

Beyond the foundational comparison, the LitCritter might recognize—and it is directed commentary—that Shelley is, in all candor, a bit unkind: "poets range" (line 18); they are inconstant. Additionally, poets, if they are stained with wealth or power" (line 19)—certainly a step or two beyond "love and fame—will "grow earthly" like the chameleons, beyond the mythical (lines 12-14), actually are.

The student, noting the final three lines, as well as the poem's title, might recognize the poem to be an admonitory apostrophe in which poets, who are of a different nature from others (line 25's "[c]hildren of a sunnier star") should refuse the opportunity characterized by wealth or power and remain, not unlike the chameleon, "[s]pirits from beyond the moon" (line 26).